

D9 Harlem Votes™

Glossary & Reference Guide

Voter Education Training

Key Terms You'll Hear at the Table and in This Training

Created by Erika L. Ewing, M.F.A.
for D9 Harlem Votes™

Glossary & Key Terms

Absentee ballot

A ballot for a voter who cannot vote in person, returned by mail or drop-off. In New York it counts if it is postmarked by Election Day and received within seven days (the postmark rule).

Activation

A D9 Harlem Votes™ street event where volunteers set up at an assigned corner to register voters and share voter information. Multiple activation sites run the same day for visibility across Harlem.

Affidavit ballot

New York's name for a provisional ballot. Poll workers must offer one to a voter whose name is not on the list for the poll site, for example, someone who moved within the state at least 30 days before Election Day as poll sites are designated by zip code.

Ballot proposals

Questions on the ballot asking voters to approve or reject proposed changes. In New York, these are often changes to the City Charter or State Constitution. Voters should familiarize themselves with what is at stake with each proposal to make an informed choice.

Board of Elections (BOE)

The government office that runs elections and processes voter registrations. New York has a State Board and local boards; the NYC Board serves the five boroughs.

Change of address

Updating the address on your voter registration. In New York, the change must reach the Board of Elections at least 15 days before an election to count for that election. If that deadline passes, the voter is still registered and can vote at the old poll site, or by affidavit ballot at the new one.

Charter amendment

A proposed change to a city or state charter, the basic governing document that sets up the structure and rules of government. Voters decide whether to approve charter amendments through ballot proposals.

Closed primary

A primary in which only voters enrolled in a party may vote in that party's primary. New York is a closed-primary state, so the party choice on the form (Box 14) decides which primary a registrant can vote in.

Early Voting

In-person voting at an assigned site during a set window before Election Day, open to all registered voters.

Election Judge

In many states, the poll worker in charge of running a polling place on Election Day, opening and closing the site, checking voters in, and handling questions about who may vote. New York does not use this title: here the trained poll workers who run the site are called Election Inspectors, serving in bipartisan teams under the Board of Elections.

General election

The election where voters choose among the parties' nominees and candidates. New York's 2026 General Election is in November.

Nonpartisan

Not tied to or favoring any party or candidate. D9 Harlem Votes™ is nonpartisan: we share accurate information and never promote a candidate, party, or position.

Provisional ballot

A ballot cast when a voter's registration cannot be confirmed at the poll site, set aside and counted once eligibility is verified. HAVA guarantees it to anyone who says they are registered. In New York it is called an affidavit ballot.

Voter registration

The process by which a person signs up to vote in their district. In New York, you must be 18, a U.S. citizen, and a state resident for at least 30 days before an election to register.

Quick Reference: Contact Information

NYC Board of Elections, Manhattan Office

200 Varick Street, 10th Floor

New York, NY 10014

Phone: 1-212-886-2100 / 1-866-VOTE-NYC

Fax: 646-638-2047

TDD/TTY: NYS Relay 711

Important Dates & Deadlines

2026 Elections

Primary Election: June 23, 2026

Golden Saturday (Registration Deadline & First Day of Early Voting): Saturday, June 13, 2026

General Election: November 3, 2026

Voter Rights Resources

NYCLU: www.nyclu.org

Brennan Center for Justice: www.brennancenter.org

Campaign Legal Center: www.campaignlegal.org

D9 Harlem Votes™ is a nonpartisan civic education coalition comprised of members of historically Black fraternities and sororities serving Harlem, NY.

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